

Word family: **fish / fishes / fished / fishing / fishery / fisherman / fisher**

Base word: fish

Plural: fish / fishes

Past tense: fished

Past participle: fished

** -ing form:** fishing

Related forms: fishery, fisherman, fisher

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Your sentence:

> “I expected to see only small **fish** and coral.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **fish** means an **aquatic animal with gills and fins that lives in water**.

繁體中文： ** **生活在水中、通常以鰓呼吸並有鰭的魚類動物；魚**

中文翻譯：

> “I expected to see only small **fish** and coral.”

「我原本只預期會看到一些小**魚**和珊瑚。」

Here:

small fish = 體型較小的魚類

1. **fish = aquatic animal (動物) — 魚**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: An animal that lives in water and typically has gills, fins, and a streamlined body.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I expected to see only small **fish** and coral.”

「我原本只預期會看到一些小**魚**和珊瑚。」

Practice 2

> “We saw colourful **fish** near the reef.”

「我們在珊瑚礁附近看到很多色彩鮮豔的**魚**。」

Practice 3

> “The lake is full of **fish**.”

「湖裡有很多**魚**。」

****fish = 生活在水中的魚類動物****

Common:

- * small fish
- * tropical fish
- * freshwater fish
- * sea fish

2. ****fish = flesh of fish used as food (食物) — 魚肉 ; 魚類食品****

****Fish**** can also refer to fish as food rather than the animal itself.

Practice 4

> “We had grilled **fish** for dinner.”

「我們晚餐吃了烤**魚**。」

Practice 5

> “She does not eat **fish**.”

「她不吃**魚類 / 魚肉**。」

****fish = 作為食物食用的魚肉或魚類食品****

For strict counting, I would show this separately because the referent shifts from:

> living animal

to:

> food/material derived from it.

3. **fish = catch fish (動詞) — 釣魚 ; 捕魚**

As a verb, **fish** means to try to catch fish.

Practice 6

> “They often **fish** in the river.”

「他們經常在河裡**釣魚**。」

Practice 7

> “We went **fishing** early in the morning.”

「我們一大早去**釣魚**。」

****fish = 以魚竿、魚網或其他方法捕捉魚類****

This is the main verb meaning.

4. **fish = search around for something (動詞 , 比喻) — 摸索 ; 掏找**

****Fish**** can figuratively mean searching awkwardly or reaching around for something.

Practice 8

> “She **fished** in her bag for her keys.”

「她在袋裡**摸索着找**鎖匙。」

Practice 9

> “He **fished** around in his pocket for some coins.”

「他在口袋裡**掏來掏去找**硬幣。」

****fish for something = 在袋、口袋、水中等地方反覆摸索尋找某物****

This is a figurative extension of trying to catch something.

Because your operating procedure normally excludes phrasal verbs, I would not promote ****fish for**

/ fish around** as separate core entries unless needed by the target sentence.

5. **fish = try to get information/praise indirectly (比喻) — 試探 ; 套話 ; 博取**

In expressions such as:

- > fish for information
- > fish for compliments

fish means trying indirectly to obtain something.

Practice 10

> “He was **fishing for information**.”

「他在**試探 / 套取資料**。」

Practice 11

> “She was clearly **fishing for compliments**.”

「她很明顯在**博取稱讚**。」

fish for something = 間接地試圖獲得資料、稱讚、反應等

Again, this is a phrasal/figurative extension rather than a new bare-word core meaning.

6. **fish = person, especially in fixed informal descriptions (人物比喻) — 某類人**

In some fixed expressions, **fish** can refer metaphorically to a person.

Examples include:

- * a big fish
- * a cold fish
- * an odd fish

Practice 12

> “He is a big **fish** in a small company.”

「他在那間小公司裡是個**重要人物**。」

Practice 13

> “She can seem like a rather cold **fish**.”

「她有時看起來像個相當**冷淡的人**。」

These are idiomatic descriptions, not a general core meaning of **fish = person**.

I would keep them as fixed expressions rather than inflate the base sense count.

Related form: **fishing**

Fishing means the activity of catching fish.

Practice 14

> “Fishing is popular in the area.”

「這個地區很流行**釣魚 / 捕魚**。」

fishing = 捕捉魚類的活動

Related form: **fishery**

A **fishery** can mean a place, industry, or area where fish are caught or raised.

Practice 15

> “The region depends on its coastal **fisheries**.”

「這個地區依賴沿海**漁業 / 漁場**。」

fishery = 捕魚、養魚或相關產業 / 水域

This is a useful domain form.

Related form: **fisher / fisherman**

fisher / fisherman

= a person who catches fish

Practice 16

> “Local **fishers** returned before sunset.”

「本地**漁民**在日落前回來。」

fisherman is traditional and common; **fisher** is gender-neutral and increasingly common in professional contexts.

Important distinction: **fish** vs **seafood**

fish

specifically means fish as animals or food.

seafood

is broader and includes:

- * fish
- * shellfish
- * other edible sea animals

So:

fish $\subset$ **seafood**

but:

seafood $\neq$ only **fish**

Important distinction: **fish** vs **fishes**

This is important.

fish

is the usual plural when referring to multiple individual fish:

> “We saw ten fish.”

fishes

is often used when referring to different species or kinds of fish, especially in scientific contexts:

> “the fishes of the Pacific”

So in your sentence:

> “small fish”

is exactly natural.

Important distinction: **fish vs fishing**

fish

can be noun or verb.

> “I saw a fish.”

> “I fish every weekend.”

fishing

usually means the activity.

> “Fishing is relaxing.”

Important distinction: **fish vs catch**

fish

= try to catch fish

catch

= successfully get or capture something

You can:

> fish all day

without:

> catching any fish.

Countability note

****Fish**** has flexible number behaviour.

Countable animal sense

Singular:

> a fish

Plural:

> fish

Species-focused plural

> fishes

Food sense

Often uncountable:

> “We ate fish.”

This is a very useful learner distinction.

The Golden Manual recommends noting countability where it materially affects natural usage.

Useful expression: ****a fish out of water — 格格不入的人****

Practice 17

> “I felt like a ****fish out of water**** at the formal dinner.”

「我在那場正式晚宴上感到非常****格格不入****。」

****a fish out of water = 身處不熟悉環境、感到不自在的人****

This is an idiom rather than a new core meaning.

Useful expression: **there are plenty more fish in the sea — 還有很多其他選擇**

Practice 18

> “Don’t worry—there are plenty more **fish in the sea**.”

「別擔心，**還有很多其他選擇 / 人選**。」

This is a figurative fixed expression, especially in relationship contexts.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

- * **fish**
- * **fished**
- * **fishing**
- * **fishery**
- * **fisher**
- * **fisherman**

Useful constructions include:

- * tropical fish
- * eat fish
- * go fishing
- * fish for information
- * fish for compliments
- * fishery
- * fish out of water

The Golden Manual says useful family forms and figurative expressions should be included, but phrasal/idiomatic material should not be miscounted as extra core meanings.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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fish — animal	生活在水中、通常以鰓呼吸並有鰭的魚類動物	
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fish — food	作為食物食用的魚肉或魚類食品	
fish — verb	以魚竿、魚網或其他方法捕捉魚類	
fish for/around	摸索、試探或間接嘗試取得某物；屬於 figurative extension	
fishing	捕捉魚類的活動	
fishery	捕魚、養魚的水域、產業或漁業系統	
fisher / fisherman	捕魚的人；漁民 / 漁夫	

For your original sentence

> “I expected to see only small **fish** and coral.”

The exact meaning is:

fish = 活在海水中的魚類動物

So:

> **small fish**

= **小魚 / 小型魚類**

For your database, I would count **3 genuinely useful core meanings** for **fish**:

1. **aquatic animal**
2. **fish as food**
3. **verb — catch fish**

I would keep **fish for information / fish around / fish out of water** as figurative or idiomatic extensions rather than inflate the core count.